about our capabilities, about the feasibility and availability of required technological infrastructure, about the viability, the schedule and cost. Dr Arunachalam stood by me like a rock throughout the entire question-answer session.

Members were skeptical and apprehensive of drift—which they felt was common among scientists. Although some questioned our ambitious proposal, everyone, even the doubting Thomases, were very excited about the idea of India having her own missile systems. In the end, we were asked by Defence Minister Venkataraman to meet him in the evening, about three hours later.

We spent the intervening time working on permutations and combinations. If they sanctioned only Rs 100 crores, how would we al ocate it? Suppose they gave us Rs 200 how would we al ocate it? Suppose they gave us Rs 200 crores, then what would we do? When we met the Defence Minister in the evening, I had a hunch we were going to get some funds at any rate. But when he suggested that we launch an integrated guided missile development programme, instead of making missiles in phases, we could not believe our ears.

We were quite dumbfounded by the Defence Minister’s